

Yanlin Wan

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EDUCATION

The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

Phd, Individualized Interdisciplinary Program

Hongkong SAR

09/2021 - 2025 Expected

Bocconi University

MSc, Economic and Social Sciences

Milan, Italy

09/2018 - 12/2020

Beijing Forestry University

BMgt, Accounting

Beijing, China

09/2014 - 06/2018

RESEARCH INTEREST

Development Economics, Behavioral Economics

JOB MARKET PAPER

Bridging the Gap: Improve Mental Health through Increased Access to Care

with Yuzhi Hao, Xu Zhang

- We evaluate a nationwide policy in China that aimed to improve population mental well-being by expanding the supply of mental healthcare resources and reducing the public stigma associated with mental illness. Using a difference-in-differences approach, we find that the policy significantly improved mental health on average, with benefits concentrated among individuals with better mental health conditions. Through a discrete choice experiment, we show that individuals with poorer mental health are more sensitive to price changes but less responsive to reduction in time costs, likely due to proximity-induced privacy concerns. Together, these findings suggest that the policy's success was driven by reduced time costs of mental healthcare for those with better mental health status. We conclude that effective mental health interventions require a two-pronged strategy: a broad approach to improve general access for the broader population, coupled with targeted efforts to remove financial barriers and provide privacy-sensitive, professional support for those with severe conditions.

WORKING PAPERS

Nudge for Sanitation: Experimental Evidence from China

with Xu Zhang

- Information provision has been suggested as a cost-effective approach to engaging the target poor in anti-poverty campaigns. However, empirical evidence shows that providing information about available public services or entitled rights alone is often insufficient to motivate behavior change. In this study, we conducted a randomized controlled trial experiment to compare the behavioral impacts of different informational nudges on villagers' participation decisions in China's Rural Toilet Revolution (RTR), which aims to boost rural development through improved living conditions. We designed six RTR advocacy videos as informational nudges based on local residents' information demand, highlighting the benefits of RTR participation, the harms of poor sanitation, and techniques for toilet upgrades, either with or without a former RTR participant calling for engagement. Our findings suggest that any relevant policy information can induce a higher self-reported willingness to participate in RTR, while highlighting the benefits or harms is more effective in motivating long-term enrollment decisions. The results reveal the importance of engagement benefits for the target audience and highlight information barrier removal as a useful nudge to promote anti-poverty campaigns like RTR. (Submitted)

Rewiring Opportunity: How Improved Internet Infrastructure Reduces Intra-City Income Inequality in China

with Xu Zhang, Yuzhi Hao, Aoqing Lyu, Masaru Yarime

- This study investigates the impact of enhanced internet infrastructure on intra-city income inequality in China. Employing a staggered difference-in-differences methodology, our analysis reveals that the Broadband China Strategic Program from 2014 to 2016 resulted in a notable reduction in the income Gini coefficients of the demonstration cities, with substantial income gains among low- and middle-income households. We argue that the improved internet infrastructure mitigated income inequality mainly by creating new employment opportunities in the service sector for low-skilled workers. Our findings underscore the pivotal role of technology in fostering inclusive economic growth

and provide valuable insights for policymakers seeking to harness investments in internet infrastructure and improve social equality in developing countries. (Submitted)

Risk tolerance, soft skills, and sectoral sorting: Experimental Evidence from India

with Raja Rajendra Timilsina, Dil B Rahut, Tetsushi Sonobe

- The persistence of informal employment in developing economies raises central economic questions: why do some workers engage with digital platforms while others remain in traditional informal markets? What are the underlying economic preferences, despite the rapid expansion of the informal gig economy? Thus, this paper addresses this puzzle by using a lab-in-the-field experiment in urban India. We develop a framework in which workers are ex-ante sorted into digital or non-digital sectors. We then conduct experiments to collect data on risk tolerance, soft skills, and working conditions, while holding mobility to be limited. Our results reveal that younger non-digital workers exhibit higher risk tolerance than digital participants, while older digital workers tend to be more risk-neutral or risk-averse. Moreover, digital workers exhibit greater self-control and openness, but lower grit and conscientiousness, relative to their traditional-sector counterparts. These findings suggest that occupational sorting in secondary labor markets reflects heterogeneous preferences over income risk, flexibility, and community-based security, rather than simple technological adoption. This sorting mechanism in a utility-maximization model with entry frictions can be formalized to a broader understanding of labor market segmentation and the dynamics of informality in developing economies. The results have implications for policies aimed at improving welfare in dual labor markets, including the design of risk-sharing mechanisms, skill-building initiatives, and regulatory frameworks for digital platforms to scale up in the future. (Submitted)

SELECTED WORKS IN PROGRESS

- Demand for Social Security Program among Informal Workers in Urban India (with Raja Rajendra Timilsina, Dil B Rahut, Ngawang Dendup, Tetsushi Sonobe)
- AI Policy in Education: A Randomized Control Experiment (with Jinghao Jia, Xu Zhang)

PRESENTATIONS

2025: Asian Development Bank Economist Forum; *International Research Society for Public Management Conference; *Atlanta Conference on Science and Innovation Policy; Asian Economic Development Conference; Asian Development Bank Institute Conference on Innovations for Sustainable Agriculture and Rural Development (scheduled)

2024: Xiamen University International Workshops on Experimental Economics; Asian Economic Development Conference; Technology, Data, and Policy Conference at Massachusetts Institute of Technology; HKUST(Guangzhou) IPE Seminar

2023: North America Meetings of Economic Science Association; Asian Pacific Public Policy Network; HKUST(Guangzhou) IPE Seminar

2022: *ShenZhen University Public Policy and Experimental Economics Workshop; *Annual Conference on Chinese Development Theory at Renmin University of China

*indicates presentation by a coauthor

AWARDS

2021-Present: Postgraduate Scholarship, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology

2025: Honorable Mention, Asian Development Bank-International Economic Association Innovative Policy Research Award

2023: First Prize, Graduate Students Development Economics Conference University of Chinese Academy of Social Sciences; Research Travel Grant

2020: Fondo Sostegno Giovani and International Organization Scholarship, Bocconi University

OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCES

United Nations Industrial Development Organization

Policy Research Intern

Brussels, Belgium

02/2020 – 07/2020

- Supervisor: Patrick Gilabert

- Participate in the study and analysis of the EU's fundamental policy areas related to UNIDO mandate
- Provide analytical support to UN House Working Group on Green Deal and project managers
- The report titled *The EU Global Response to COVID-19* is available at UNIDO website

Beijing Forestry University

Research Assistant

Beijing, China

12/2014 - 12/2015

- Supervisor: Dahong Zhang
- Literature review and data collection for the research project titled *Research on Ecological Safety Index (ESI)*

TEACHING EXPERIENCES

Spring 2023: Behavioral Economics and Public Policy (Graduate)

Fall 2022: Experimental Economics and Organizational Behavior (Graduate)

SKILLS

Programming: Stata, LaTeX, ArcGIS, R, Python

Language: Chinese(Native), English(Fluent), Italian (Basic)

REFEREES

Assistant Professor Xu Zhang

Society Hub, The Hongkong University of Science and Technology (Guangzhou)

✉ xuzhang@hkust-gz.edu.cn

Associate Professor Masaru Yarime

Division of Public Policy, The Hongkong University of Science and Technology

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Assistant Professor Zihan Hu

Department of Economics, Singapore Management University

✉ zihanhu@smu.edu.sg